



Echoes of DOOM

Set in mysterious India, Tim Parks' new novel is yet another journey into the heart of darkness

By Brinda Bose

D*reams of Rivers and Seas* is Tim Parks' 14th novel, and the first set outside Europe—in distant, exotic, mysterious, polluted, beggar-infested, Delhi-belly-causing India. The man who was “plagued, perhaps blessed, by dreams of rivers and seas” is the absent axis of this intriguing, disturbing novel, dead from before the story begins. What makes this novel intriguing and disturbing is not so much its unusual plotline and premise, but its churning epicentre, throwing up a bunch of muted but unhappy whispers: surely, surely, this is ironical, a 21st century (albeit unnecessary) exercise in mea culpa for all the Forsters and the Conrads that sang before, an antiphrastic paeon both to dead white do-gooders in hearts of darkness and

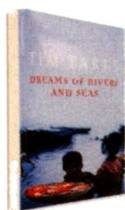
PARKS' NOVEL IS INSPIRED BY THE FAMOUS BRITISH ANTHROPOLOGIST AND SEMIOTICIAN GREGORY BATESON

to the heat and dust of erstwhile colonies that have continued to lure generations of intellectual and sensitive westerners to their doom?

Albert James, scientist-turned-anthropologist dies (but not of prostrate cancer as his son intuitively suspects) pursuing his life's work in the devastating, dehumanising and yet (surprisingly) inspiring Third World in the company of his doctor wife Helen, who (hardly surprisingly) runs a clinic for the poor and sick of Delhi. Their PhD-pursuant son John instantly flies out from London to share his mother's grief and take a last look at his father's body. He is denied both experiences as Helen has sealed the coffin and the past with a quiet determination that John is quite unable to rupture. The mystery and threat of this scenario are further exacerbated by the arrival of a would-be biographer of James, Paul, whom Helen rebuffs and seduces alternately with appreciable aplomb, and the convenient popping up of nubile young women, white (Eliane) and brown (Jasmeet), apparently in love with son and father, sometimes one or the other and sometimes both—often hysterical, and always self-absorbed.

So what, then, redeems this Tim Parks' foray into the egregious East? It is (and this is the true irony of the novel) the dead James, who is ghosted from the famous British anthropologist and semiotician Gregory Bateson. Parks deliberately poses a perplex with his epigraph, in which he first cites his inspiration and then warns readers not to look for the truth about Bateson in this novel, who never even “lived in Delhi”. The novel is at its best when it carouses with the quasi-fictional (and now dead) James through labyrinths of biology, sociology, kinetics and linguistics, and enacts the impossibility of mapping the anatomy of an incandescent mind.

It is perhaps at its worst when attempting the sexual; unfortunately, there is far more of it than called for in Parks' *Dreams*. Fumbling and bumbling, bodies collide and invariably end in whimpers. There appears to be an obsessive interest in May-December couplings. And while James' ghost strides through the novel like a colossus, the novel ends with a ghoulish twist. “*Du calme, du calme*”, a wise white doctor in Conrad had advised a colonialist heading to tropical jungles in the late 19th century. In the late 20th, the passage of James and his assorted associates to India is still strangely beset by the very same affliction, the suicide of sanity amidst the noxious smells and sights of Delhi.



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